

GENERAL IR

- All IR debate collapses into different values/interests each country has.
- Countries might want one thing, and the people might want another.
- IR debates → hard to generalize.
- Application → hard to generalize, since countries have different values, characterizations, etc.

Countries generally want:

- Power
 - Economic interests — jobs, strong currency, better labour laws (careful: countries don't want "better labour laws," *people* do; states want economic growth).
 - Environmental considerations — lowering environmental damage.
 - The more environmentally good, the more expensive it often is.
 - EU countries have high regulations → their economic interests are already sorted.
 - Military interests
 - Primary concern is internal; external military projection is often also about internal interests.
 - Stronger military = stronger borders.
 - Leverage
 - Methods to influence outcomes (e.g., dependence, prisoner swaps).
 - Can be used as a mechanism to justify many strategic actions.
-

CHINA

Political

- Controlled by CCP.
- Democracy = no. One-party rule.
- CCP wants to avoid scrutiny.
- Wage laws etc. decided by CCP.
- *“What keeps Xi Jinping in check?”*
 - The top hierarchy in the CCP (Politburo Standing Committee).
- Xi Jinping's image matters because internal elite politics is competitive.

Economic

- **US–China Trade War**
 - Semiconductor control.
 - US doesn't manufacture most chips → outsources to Taiwan, Korea.
 - US imposes heavy tariffs.
 - US actively facilitates competition with China.
- **Dumping**
 - China sells products at artificially low prices.
 - Cheap labour → lower production costs.
 - State subsidies help them undercut others.
 - Strategy: win short-term, kill competitors, later raise prices.
- US still dependent on Chinese imports → cannot tariff everything.

- Trump → tariffs only where reasonable competitors exist; avoids sectors where China has monopoly.
- **OBOR/BRI**
 - Gives loans with **infrastructure as collateral**
 - High interest, few conditions → many countries default.
 - Example: Sri Lanka's Hambantota Port (99-year lease).
 - China gets assets but NOT money → creates distress for China.
- **Housing crisis**
 - Oversupply → money stuck → economic slowdown.
- **COVID effects**
 - China = manufacturing hub → lockdowns hit production badly.
- **Aging population crisis**
 - People don't want kids; low birth rate.
 - Working class shrinking.
 - Some young people are leaving (though emigration is not very high—just politically sensitive).
 - “Too many jobs, not enough workers” → productivity dip.

Military

- Territorial disputes with many neighbours.
- Projects strength.
- Held back by US presence in South China Sea.
- Taiwan has explicit US backing.

- Limited foreign interventions compared to Russia/US.
-

USA

Political

- Checks on executive: Supreme Court + Congress.
- Judges appointed by the Senate.
- **Immigration dynamics:**
 - Lots of immigrants.
 - Some bring drugs (fentanyl mainly comes through *cartels and smuggling networks*, not “immigrants generally” — the speaker simplified).
 - Trump → stricter border.
 - ICE handles deportations.
 - Some 2nd/3rd gen immigrants → very right-wing (example: Nikki Haley).
 - Internal competition for resources → hostility between immigrant groups.
 - Not all Black people vote left, not all White people vote right.

Economic

- US Dollar dominance.
 - Chinese Yuan is the closest alternative (though still far behind).
- US dislikes any pivot away from USD.
- Most trade is dollar-settled → double conversion for countries like India.
- **Skilled immigration:**

- H1B visas → limited; given to highly-skilled applicants.

Military

- Israel–Palestine
 - You wrote: *“There is no debate on it. It’s one of the biggest genocides...”*
→ **This is an opinion, not a fact. Keep note.**
→ (this is not to say that it’s justified, it’s just not a “fact” as much as it is an “openion”)
 - US consistently backs Israel; vetoes UNSC resolutions.
- Alliances with Japan, South Korea.
- AUKUS
- Actively counters China in South China Sea.

Other US Politics

Abortion Laws

- Major partisan divide.
- **Right wing (Republicans):** generally pro-life; want strict abortion limits or bans; argue states should decide.
- **Left wing (Democrats):** pro-choice; want federal protection for abortion access; frame it as healthcare + bodily autonomy.

Gun Laws

- **Right wing (Republicans):** support loose gun laws; strong defenders of the Second Amendment; oppose strict regulation; see guns as personal freedom + protection.
- **Left wing (Democrats):** support tighter gun control; favour background checks, waiting periods, and sometimes assault-weapon bans; argue regulation reduces violence.

Prison-Industrial Complex & Defund-the-Police

- **Prison-industrial complex:** idea that prisons operate like an industry where private prisons, contractors, and political incentives benefit from higher incarceration.
 - **Left wing:** argues the system encourages mass incarceration and harms minority communities.
 - **Right wing:** generally rejects the idea that it's "industrial" and supports tough-on-crime policies.
 - **Defund-the-police:** not abolishing police; reallocate part of police budgets to social services (mental health, housing, education).
 - **Left wing:** supports shifting funds to root-cause prevention.
 - **Right wing:** argues defunding weakens law enforcement and increases crime.
 -
-

MIDDLE EAST

Iran vs Saudi Arabia

- Fight for Islamic leadership (Shia vs Sunni).
- Yemen:
 - Iran backs Houthis (control west + coast).
 - Saudi backs the internationally recognised government (controls east).
 - Houthis threaten oil export routes through the Red Sea.
 - Goal: weaken Saudi Arabia economically.
(Because SA supports the govt there, so the weaker the govt, the more control the Houthis have.)

Sudan

- RSF vs SAF.

- Initially overthrew government together → conflict after.
 - West + African Union → pro-SAF.
 - UAE → allegedly backs RSF (denies it).
 - Sudan rejects African Union peacekeeping often.
-

RUSSIA

- Cold War history → US vs USSR.
 - USSR breakup → many new states.
 - Some have Russian influence; some want EU/NATO.
 - Ukraine war not purely one-sided; Ukraine sustained by Western support.
 - Russia facing economic + military strain.
 - Trump ambiguous (“dovish”).
 - Rumours of ties with Russia exist, but not substantiated.
 - Putin violated expectations → Trump became more supportive of Ukraine (this is interpretive, not confirmed fact).
-

EUROPEAN UNION

- UK left (Brexit), uses Pound.
- Eurozone = countries using Euro.
- EU membership requires:

- Democracy
 - Weakening Russian influence
 - Stable economy
 - Adopting Euro
 - Eastern Europe poorer → less say in EU.
 - Immigration debate → Left wing (allow), Right wing (restrict).
 - EU cares about Ukraine because:
 - Border security
 - Trade routes
 - Energy transit (though oil is less relevant now; gas is more relevant).
 - Trump supports Ukraine because he is obsessed with his image and wants to “solve all conflicts in the world”.
-

AFRICA

- Sudan conflict (already above).
- Sahel states: Niger, Mali, Burkina Faso.
- Anti-democratic military coups.
- Pulled out of ECOWAS (West-backed democratic bloc).
- Sanctions imposed → they distanced further.
- French influence declining; Russian influence rising.
- Wagner Group involvement likely, but speaker said this coup cycle wasn't directly Wagner-led → Russia supports after the coups.

MACRO NOTES

- More authoritarian = easier to push rapid economic reform.
- Democracies = slow, more welfare spending, stronger labour laws → lower productivity sometimes.
- For adjudicating IR:
 - Build knowledge through practice.
 - Know whether something happened; why/how is debatable.
 - If given facts, rely on debate analysis.
- IMF = powerful bailout lender.
- ADB = Asian equivalent (not exactly, but similar function).
- World Bank = influential development lender.